AI EXPLAINED SIMPLY

The AI Fact-Check Cheat Sheet

Companion to "Why AI Makes Things Up (Hallucinations Explained)" — AI Explained Simply

What a hallucination is

An AI answer that sounds confident and fluent but is false or invented. Language models predict the most likely next words; they do not look facts up, so a made-up case or quote can read just as smoothly as a real one (OpenAI, "Why language models hallucinate", 2025).

Why it happens

1. **Prediction, not lookup**: the model generates plausible text word by word.
2. **Tests reward guessing**: OpenAI researchers argue most evaluations give credit for a lucky guess and nothing for answering "I don't know", so models learn to guess.

The real example

In *Mata v. Avianca* (S.D.N.Y., 2023), lawyers filed a brief citing court cases that ChatGPT had invented. Judge P. Kevin Castel fined the lawyers and their firm $5,000 (22 June 2023).

The 5-step check

1. **Ask for sources** for every name, number, date and quote.
2. **Open each source** yourself. If the link or document does not exist, the claim is unverified.
3. **Search the exact quote or title** in a normal search engine.

4. **Cross-check** important facts with a second, independent source.
5. **Give the AI permission to say "I don't know"**, for example: "If you are not sure, say so instead of guessing."

Red flags

- Very specific details (case numbers, page numbers, statistics) with no link.
- Sources that "almost" match a real title.
- A confident tone on an obscure topic.

Sources

- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Mata_v._Avianca,_Inc.
- https://law.justia.com/cases/federal/district-courts/new-york/nysdce/1:2022cv01461/575368/54
- https://openai.com/index/why-language-models-hallucinate/
- https://arxiv.org/pdf/2509.04664

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